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US Semiconductors

AI Infra Summit Day 2: The Network Is the Computer

CITI'S TAKE

We attended Day 2 of AI Infra Summit in Santa Clara, CA and focused on networking specific takeaways. As AI workloads become more reasoning-intensive and context-rich, infrastructure scaling will depend not only on expanding compute resources but also on innovations across memory hierarchies, HBM, system architectures, and networking fabrics to sustain performance and efficiency.

Broadcom (Hasan Siraj, VP of Product Management): Broadcom made the case that Ethernet is becoming the preferred interconnect for large-scale AI infrastructure, and Broadcom's Tomahawk and Jericho families are positioned as the networking foundation for those deployments. Broadcom has a complete Ethernet AI networking portfolio (NICs, switches, software). The Tomahawk roadmap has steadily doubled bandwidth, reaching 102.4 Tbps with Tomahawk 6, enabling larger AI clusters. Higher efficiency translates into lower power, cooling, and infrastructure costs, which Broadcom claims delivers over 30% lower 5-year TCO compared with alternative approaches.

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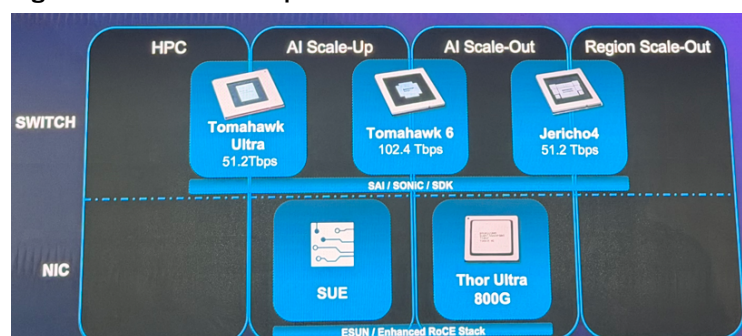
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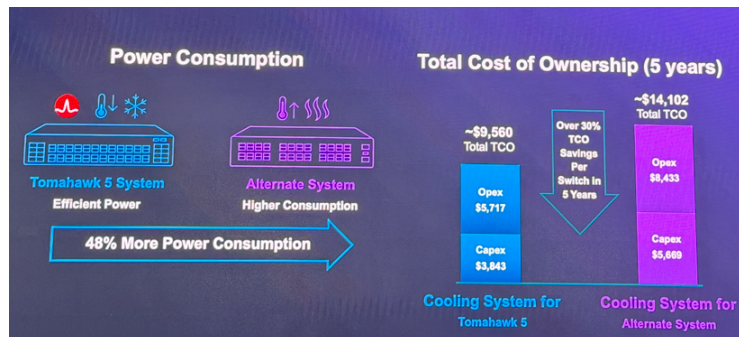
Figure 1. Broadcom: Complete AI Ethernet Portfolio



Source: Broadcom

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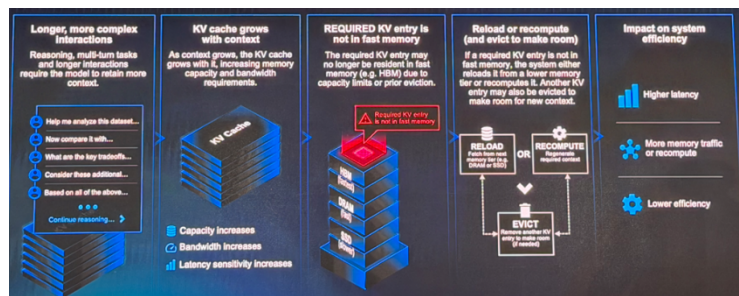
Figure 2. Broadcom: TCO Savings with Efficient Architectures



Source: Broadcom

Marvell (Dave Lazovsky, EVP and GM, Data Center Networking Group): Marvell highlighted that future AI infrastructure scaling will depend not only on more compute, but increasingly on innovations in memory hierarchy, high-bandwidth memory, system architecture, and networking fabric to support larger reasoning workloads and long-context AI applications efficiently. A key challenge is the rapid growth of the KV cache, which stores contextual information needed for reasoning. As context windows expand, KV data can exceed the capacity of fast memory (HBM), forcing systems to reload data from slower memory tiers or recompute context. This increases latency, memory traffic, power consumption, and reduces overall system efficiency.

Figure 3. Growing memory challenges of reasoning



Source: Marvell

Samsung (In Dong Kim, VP of DRAM Product Planning & Business Enablement): Samsung sees AI evolving from Generative AI → Agentic AI → Physical AI (digital twins, humanoid robots, autonomous vehicles). This transition is expected to drive approximately: 3x growth in training infrastructure demand and 100x growth in inference demand, making memory, storage, power efficiency, and thermals increasingly important. Samsung highlighted that HBM (High Bandwidth Memory) performance has been improving roughly 2x every generation. HBM4E Improvements include 16 TB/s bandwidth per GPU, 20% better performance per watt versus HBM4, and 10% lower thermal resistance than HBM4. HBM5 is expected to deliver 2x performance relative to HBM4E, 20% improvement in performance per watt, and 20% lower thermal resistance. Samsung positioned zHBM as a potential step-change beyond conventional HBM with 4–8x higher performance per GPU, 3x better performance per watt, and 75–90% lower thermal resistance versus HBM5 (0.1x–0.25x thermal resistance). Samsung also discussed Z-NAND, an SLC-based NAND technology utilizing TSV stacking with read performance comparable to LPDDR5 DRAM, significantly higher capacity and 10x the bit density of DRAM. Sampling is expected in 2028. Samsung views Z-NAND as the first step toward high-bandwidth flash memory, potentially bridging the gap between DRAM and NAND in AI systems.

AWS (Peter DeSantis, SVP of Foundational AI Models, Custom Silicon, and Quantum Computing): AWS's infrastructure strategy has been driven by increasing hardware specialization. After recognizing the need for deeper customization in cloud virtualization, AWS acquired Annapurna Labs in 2015, laying the foundation for its silicon roadmap. This led to the launch of Graviton in 2018, a reimagining of the general-purpose processor optimized specifically for cloud workloads. The introduction of Inferentia marked AWS's first major AI accelerator and triggered a broader pivot in its hardware strategy, evolving through Trainium generations and generating significant excitement around Trainium 4. A key differentiator for Trainium is its superior memory bandwidth per dollar, which is critical for AI training economics and token efficiency. AWS is also focused on compressing the time from chip fabrication to production AI workloads by innovating across the entire stack, from silicon to software and large-scale deployments such as the Rainier cluster. The company emphasizes balancing test and production capacity as AI demand scales. Architecturally, Trainium is built on a systolic array design with strong software integration, enabling developers to use native PyTorch support and run a wide range of models from ecosystems like Hugging Face with minimal effort.

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